

THE FIRST PEOPLES OF THIS LAND

Before there were trails, there were paths. Before there were paths, there was a people who had learned this landscape so completely — its plants, its animals, its water, its seasons — that they were able to live in it not as visitors but as inhabitants, for ten thousand years after the glacier retreated.

The Abenaki people inhabited the interior of what is now Vermont, New Hampshire, and western Maine — the mountain zones, the river corridors, the boreal forests. They knew the sugar maple, the fiddlehead fern, the ramp, and the trout long before any field guide existed. They knew which rivers ran which direction and why, which slopes held snow in May and which didn't, which mushrooms would kill you and which ones were worth the walk.

The Penobscot people — whose name belongs now to the great river that drains the Maine wilderness — lived along that river system and its tributaries, a relationship with water so deep and specific that their knowledge of the Penobscot watershed represents thousands of years of accumulated ecological understanding that no book can fully contain.

The Wampanoag people inhabited the coastal and inland areas of what is now Massachusetts and Rhode Island. The Mohegan and Pequot peoples inhabited the woodlands of Connecticut.

This land was not empty when European settlers arrived. It was known. It was managed — through fire, through harvest, through a sophistication of ecological relationship that produced the landscape that those settlers called wilderness. Much of what we think of as New England's

natural bounty — the diversity of plant life in the understory, the openness of certain forest structures, the abundance of game in specific areas — is partly the legacy of Indigenous land management practiced over centuries.

We name this here not as a footnote but as a foundation. When you learn to read this landscape, you are joining a tradition of observation and knowledge that began long before this book, or any book, existed. Some of what you will find in the chapters that follow — which plants heal, which mushrooms kill, which river crossings are safe in which seasons — descends in a direct line from knowledge that was never written down, only lived. Pay attention to it accordingly.